GBL

Generating Better Livelihoods
for Grant Recipients

www.finmark.org.za/GBL/



What does it take to help someone move from receiving a grant to building a livelihood?

Relational livelihood support in practice

Linking, supporting, sustaining: Understanding frontline practice and GBL participant progression

3B

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IN AFRICA

INSIDE

Contents

Overview 03

Background 06

How the insights were generated 07

What frontline practice looks like 08

Profiling: Understanding the person behind the pathway 08

Linking: Making opportunities reachable 11

Supporting: The relationship that holds the journey together 12

Sustaining: Keeping participants moving 13

Three frontline experiences 14

The Linkages Facilitator–Linkages Champion relationship 17

What makes frontline practice effective? 19

What continues to constrain progress? 22

From frontline support to participant progression 24

What this means for the GBL model 25

What this means for continued investment 26

The overall lesson 27

01 —— OVERVIEW

Overview

The Generating Better Livelihoods for Grant Recipients (GBL) pilot is designed to support social protection beneficiaries as they move towards sustainable livelihoods. Understanding whether this support works requires looking at both the participants' experiences and outcomes, and what happens on the ground between programme design and participant progression.

While participant research helps explain what changes for participants, research on frontline practitioners helps explain what makes those changes possible. Together, the two perspectives provide a fuller understanding of how the GBL model supports livelihood progression.

This learning brief examines the frontline experience. The frontline practitioners refer to GBL Linkages Facilitators and SASSA Linkages Champions who work directly with participants. It looks at how they support participants, the conditions that enable or constrain their work, and what their experience tells us about strengthening the GBL model.

People may need to rebuild confidence before they are ready to pursue an opportunity. They may need help navigating an institution before they can access support. Even where people have the skills and motivation to move forward, a lack of jobs, markets, transport or other resources can prevent them from doing so.

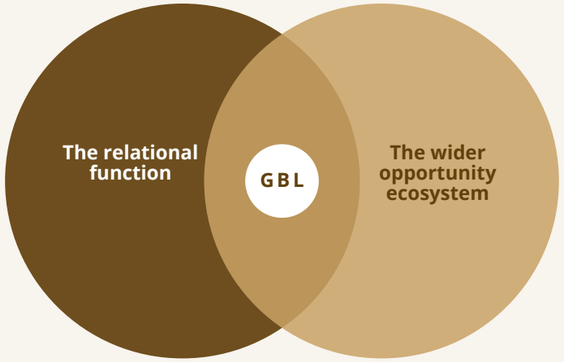
The research on frontline practitioners shows why the relationships around participants matter. Linkages facilitators and linkages champions do more than link participants to opportunities. They help participants understand their options, navigate systems, solve problems, build confidence and stay engaged when circumstances make progress difficult.



In the GBL model, coaching refers to the ongoing accompaniment of participants through goal-setting, problem-solving, encouragement, referrals and follow-up support as they pursue livelihood opportunities. This makes coaching one of the central mechanisms of the GBL model. It provides continuity between the different forms of support and helps participants move from awareness of an opportunity towards action and, ultimately, livelihood progression.

At the same time, the research shows the limitations of frontline support. Coaching can help build capability and confidence, but it cannot create jobs in weak local economies, nor can it remove every material constraint that a household may face.

The lesson for GBL is therefore twofold: the relational function needs protection and strengthening, while the wider opportunity ecosystem around participants also needs to work. Opportunity ecosystems refer to the networks of employers, training providers, government programmes, financial services, markets and support organisations that participants rely on to pursue livelihoods.



Both need to work



Background

The GBL pilot is designed to connect recipients of the Child Support Grant (CSG) and COVID-19 Social Relief of Distress (SRD) Grant to pathways into employment, entrepreneurship and further skills development.

The project adapts the globally recognised BRAC Graduation Model to the South African context. It brings together support for basic needs, productive livelihoods, employment linkages, and intensive coaching, recognising that people living in poverty often need sustained, coordinated support rather than a single intervention.

Linkages facilitators, based at implementation sites, work alongside participants over time. They help participants identify their goals, navigate opportunities, overcome practical barriers and stay engaged.

The Department of Social Development (DSD) leads the programme, with the South African Social Security Agency (SASSA) and National Development Agency (NDA), and FinMark Trust implements it with technical support from BRAC International.

The Centre for Social Development in Africa (CSDA) at the University of Johannesburg serves as the GBL learning partner. On behalf of FinMark Trust, it conducted the research that informs this brief, generating practice-based evidence to support adaptive learning and guide future institutionalisation of the programme.

This summary of the learning brief draws on interviews with frontline practitioners to understand what happens between programme design and participant outcomes. It covers what frontline staff do, what enables them to do it, what gets in the way, and what their experience tells us about the future of GBL.

WHO DELIVERS GBL



How the insights were generated

The findings are based on 18 qualitative in-depth interviews conducted in March 2026 with 10 Linkages Facilitators and 8 Linkages Champions across seven implementation sites in KwaZulu-Natal, Gauteng and the Free State.

The interviews explored how practitioners understand their roles, how they work with participants, how they identify and pursue opportunities, the challenges they encounter, and what they believe contributes to participant progression.

This brief complements the learning from research with GBL participants by looking at the same journey from the perspective of the people providing frontline support. Where participant research helps explain what changes for participants, this research examines the work that sits behind those changes.

18

IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS



10 LINKAGES FACILITATORS

8 LINKAGES CHAMPIONS

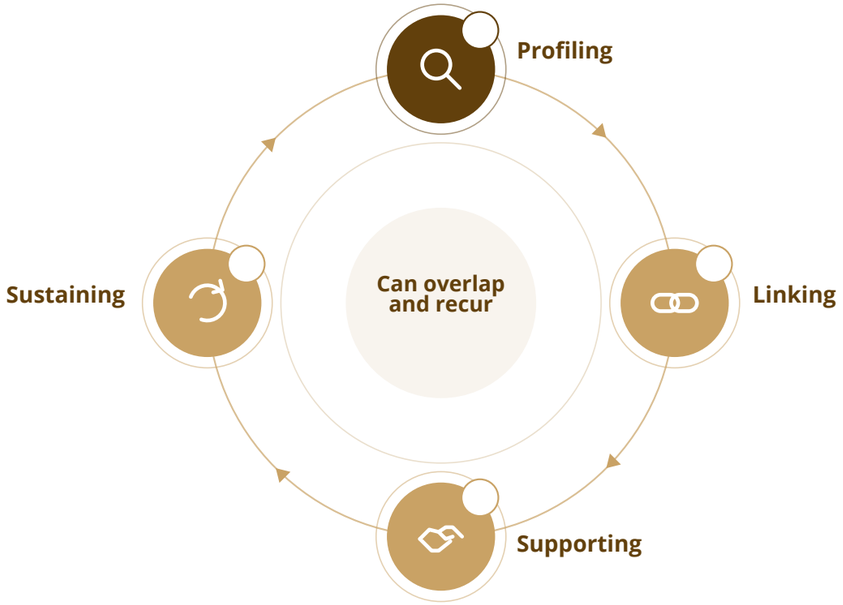
7 IMPLEMENTATION SITES

- KwaZulu-Natal
- Gauteng
- Free State

MARCH 2026

What frontline practice looks like

Frontline practice is broader and more intensive than the term "linkages" might suggest. Practitioners describe a role that moves between four interconnected functions:



In some ways, these functions appear to be separate stages; however, the research found that they can overlap and recur as participants move through the programme.

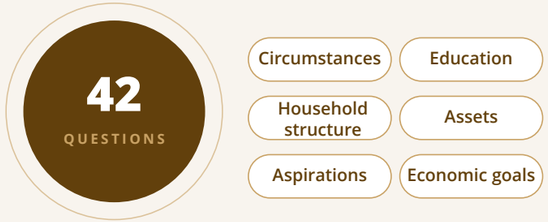
Profiling: Understanding the person behind the pathway

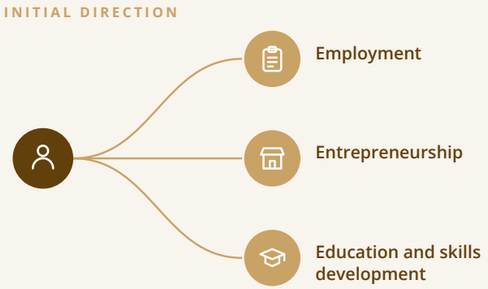
Profiling is the starting point for understanding where a participant is coming from and what kind of pathway may be appropriate. The 42-question profiling process considers participants' circumstances, education, household structure, assets, aspirations and economic goals. It helps practitioners guide whether employment, entrepreneurship or education and skills development is the most appropriate initial direction.

By identifying both aspirations and barriers early, profiling helps practitioners match participants to opportunities that are more realistic, relevant and achievable.

Profiling also reveals what may never appear on a CV or application form. Practitioners described participants disclosing food insecurity, domestic conflict, trauma, grief, emotional distress and difficult household circumstances during the process. Some participants became visibly distressed while discussing their lives.

This means profiling serves a purpose beyond data collection. It requires practitioners to listen, respond with empathy and recognise when a participant's immediate circumstances may need attention before an economic pathway can progress.







Linking: Making opportunities reachable

Although participants evidently need opportunities, knowing one exists is different from being able to access it. Frontline practitioners bridge this gap. They map local resources, identify training and employment opportunities, approach organisations and businesses, engage government departments and build relationships with people who can open doors for participants.

In areas where formal opportunities are limited, this can mean actively creating connections rather than waiting for opportunities to come to the programme. Practitioners need a practical understanding of their local economies and the systems participants must navigate. This includes knowing how funding applications work, where enterprise support is available, how businesses are registered and which organisations can provide training or services through referrals.



They also need to understand the community environment in which they work. Building relationships with ward councillors, traditional leaders, community organisations and local institutions can be essential in establishing trust and gaining entry into communities.

Linking is both technical and relational. It requires knowledge of opportunity systems as well as the ability to build enough trust for those opportunities to become accessible to participants.

Supporting: The relationship that holds the journey together

Check-ins · Goal-setting · Encouragement · Mentoring · Problem-solving · Follow-up

The research shows that the most important frontline work often happens after a linkage has been made. Participants may need help completing forms, preparing for training, following up with an institution, resolving a problem or simply finding the confidence to continue. This is where coaching becomes visible.

Frontline practitioners described regular check-ins, goal-setting, encouragement, mentoring, problem-solving and follow-up as central to their work. They also described a more human form of support – listening when participants are distressed, helping them regain confidence and remaining alongside them when progress is slower than expected.

One practitioner described the approach as having a "heart of helping" and being willing to "go the extra mile". These qualities are essential because many participants enter the programme with previous experiences of exclusion, disappointment or broken promises. Building trust can take time.

A participant who feels ashamed about being unable to complete a written assessment may need someone to advocate for them and help negotiate with a trainer. Someone who has lost confidence following disability or trauma may need encouragement to consider further education. For a participant facing severe hardship at home, the immediate priority may be a referral to social support before they can focus on longer-term livelihood goals.

While these activities may seem peripheral, they are necessary to make livelihood progression possible.

"heart of helping"
and being willing to ***"go the extra mile"***

Sustaining: Keeping participants moving

Progress does not always happen quickly. Participants may face long waits for training, funding, employment opportunities, or other support. During these periods, motivation can fall, and trust can weaken.

Frontline practitioners spend considerable time maintaining engagement. They make follow-up calls, conduct home visits, manage expectations, encourage participants to keep trying and help them respond when circumstances change. This can be demanding when participants are dealing with hunger, caregiving responsibilities, transport difficulties or the need to leave their community temporarily in search of income.

In these circumstances, sustaining engagement means recognising the pressures competing with longer-term goals and finding practical ways to keep the connection alive.

KEEPING THE CONNECTION ALIVE

Long waits for training, funding, employment opportunities, or other support



PRESSURES COMPETING WITH LONGER-TERM GOALS

- Hunger
- Caregiving responsibilities
- Transport difficulties
- Search for income

Three frontline experiences

The frontline interviews show how these functions come together in practice.

01 Rebuilding confidence and opening a new pathway

In KwaMashu, the Linkages Facilitator supported a young woman whose life had changed dramatically after she became permanently disabled in a car accident during her matric year. The participant had withdrawn and lost confidence in her future. Through ongoing encouragement, counselling and practical guidance, the Linkages Facilitator helped her rebuild her confidence and pursue tertiary education.

At the time of the interview, the participant was in her second year of a teaching degree. While this outcome is significant, so is the process that preceded it.



The first step was helping the participant believe that another future was possible.



02 Responding to immediate vulnerability

At a site in the Free State, a Linkages Champion encountered a household where a participant was caring for a child who was mute and needed additional support. The child could not attend mainstream school. The Linkages Champion helped the household access a care dependency grant and connected them to a specialised educational facility.

In another case, a Linkages Facilitator and a Linkages Champion encountered a young mother living in severe material hardship with a newborn. They mobilised community support for food, clothing and other immediate needs.

These interventions do not represent GBL's end goal. Rather, they demonstrate why frontline practitioners need to understand the whole person and the conditions affecting their ability to pursue a livelihood. Sometimes sustaining a livelihood pathway starts by helping a household and/or individual stabilise.

WHAT THE HOUSEHOLD WAS CONNECTED TO

- Care dependency grant
- Specialised educational facility
- Community support for food, clothing and other immediate needs

03 Turning exclusion into participation

In another case, a participant with limited literacy skills was reluctant to attend formal training because of the shame associated with being unable to complete written assessments. Rather than allowing this barrier to close the opportunity, the Linkages Facilitator approached the training provider and negotiated an alternative oral assessment.

The participant completed the training and secured access to funding. While the intervention appeared relatively minor, it resolved the exclusion. This demonstrates the role of frontline practitioners as mediators between participants and systems that are often designed without their circumstances in mind.

RESOLVING THE EXCLUSION



The Linkages Facilitator–Linkages Champion relationship

The research highlights an important distinction between Linkages Facilitators and Linkages Champions. The former are dedicated GBL personnel. Their primary responsibility is participant progression, which gives them the time and continuity needed for regular coaching, home visits, follow-up and progression monitoring.

Linkages Champions are SASSA officials who were seconded to support GBL in the 2024/25 financial year.

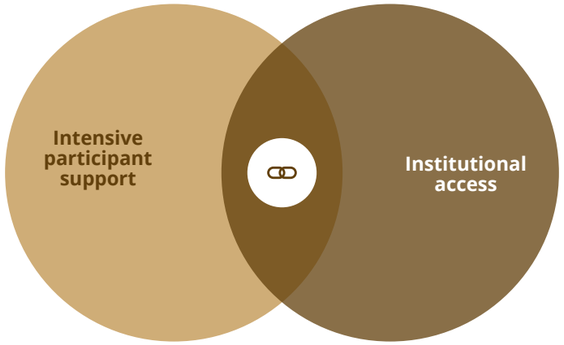
This was done to test whether the Linkages Facilitator role could be incorporated in SASSA's future delivery model. However, the officials supported the GBL's coaching function while continuing their existing grant administration responsibilities. This created a different set of strengths and constraints.

	Linkages Facilitators	Linkages Champions
Primary role	Dedicated GBL coaching and participant progression	SASSA grant administration and supporting the GBL coaching function
Key strength	Continuity, intensive coaching and follow-up	Institutional access, data capturing experience, grant systems and social protection linkages
Key constraint	Transport and administrative demands	Competing SASSA responsibilities and workload
Unique contribution	Sustained participant accompaniment	Connection to SASSA systems, referrals and institutional legitimacy

The distinction between these roles is important. Linkages champions bring important institutional assets to the model. Their access to SASSA systems, grant information, referral mechanisms and official vehicles makes a significant difference, especially when participants need to navigate the social protection system. But their ability to provide continuous coaching is constrained when GBL responsibilities compete with their core SASSA duties.

The evidence points to a clear principle: intensive coaching requires dedicated capacity. Together, the two roles combine intensive participant support with institutional access, creating a bridge between livelihood opportunities and the social protection system.

While institutional partners remain essential, participant accompaniment is most effective when supported by dedicated capacity rather than relying solely on staff with competing responsibilities.



"intensive coaching requires dedicated capacity"

What makes frontline practice effective?

Across the interviews, several capabilities emerge consistently.

01

Relational capability
Practitioners need patience, empathy, active listening, emotional maturity and the ability to build trust without judgement.

02

Coaching capability
They need to help participants set goals, identify next steps, remain accountable and translate opportunities into action.

03

Opportunity and market knowledge
They need practical knowledge of local employment, enterprise, training and funding ecosystems.

04

Community legitimacy
They need to navigate local leadership, institutions and community structures and establish trust.

05

Problem-solving and advocacy
They need to intervene when institutional processes or participant circumstances create barriers.

06

Referral and psychosocial awareness
They need to recognise when a participant's needs exceed their role and facilitate appropriate referrals.

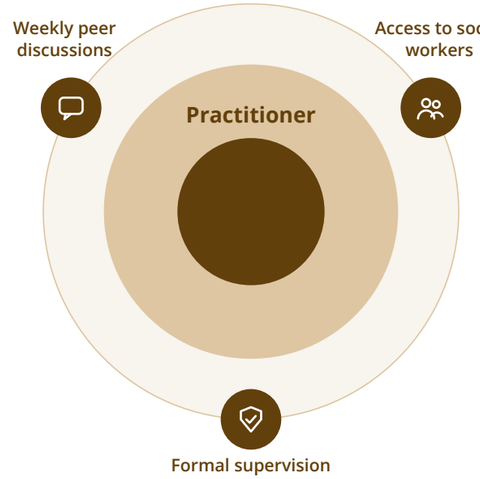


These capabilities cannot be developed through technical training alone. Frontline practitioners described the value of formal induction and training in areas such as coaching, personal mastery, financial literacy, emotional management, community mapping and the asset-based community development approach.

They also emphasised the importance of practical, face-to-face learning and ongoing development. Equally important is the support provided to practitioners themselves.

Working every day with people experiencing poverty, trauma and household distress carries an emotional burden. Weekly peer discussions, access to social workers and formal supervision help practitioners process difficult cases and maintain appropriate professional boundaries.

Supporting the people who provide support is a valuable part of programme quality.



FORMAL INDUCTION AND TRAINING

- Coaching
- Personal mastery
- Financial literacy
- Emotional management
- Community mapping
- Asset-based community development

What continues to constrain progress?

The frontline experience reinforces findings from the participant research: many barriers sit outside the programme itself.

Time lags
Long gaps between profiling, training and funding can weaken participant confidence and make it harder to maintain momentum.

Household pressures
Hunger, caregiving responsibilities and the need to secure immediate income can take priority over longer-term livelihood goals.

Weak local opportunity ecosystems
In communities with high unemployment, business closures and limited training or enterprise opportunities, practitioners may struggle to find viable pathways even for motivated participants.

Transport
Long distances, high taxi costs and limited access to official vehicles affect both participant access and frontline outreach.

Administrative demands
Profiling, intervention plans, monitoring and reporting requirements can reduce the time practitioners have available for direct participant engagement.



MANY BARRIERS SIT OUTSIDE THE PROGRAMME

These constraints are important because they change how we should interpret participant progression. Progress may take different forms and happen at different speeds. A participant may have developed confidence, completed training, started saving, returned to education or taken the first steps towards an enterprise before generating an income. Equally, a participant may have received strong coaching but still be unable to progress because of the limited, viable opportunities in the local economy.

PROGRESS MAY TAKE DIFFERENT FORMS



STRONG COACHING, LIMITED OPPORTUNITY



Limited, viable opportunities in the local economy

From frontline support to participant progression

Across the interviews, practitioners described participants progressing into training, further education, enterprise activities and employment opportunities. While progression varied across contexts, frontline staff consistently linked positive movement to sustained coaching and support.

The participant and frontline research point to a common pathway:



Frontline support helps participants move through this pathway, but the journey is not linear. A participant may move forward, encounter a barrier and take a step back. They may need to stabilise their household before returning to a livelihood goal. They may complete training but wait months for funding. They may start a business but struggle because the local market is too small.

For these reasons, coaching is valuable. It provides continuity across these changes and helps participants keep moving towards their goals. This reinforces a broader lesson for GBL – coaching and opportunity must work together.

Coaching without opportunities can build confidence without creating sufficient economic pathways. Opportunities without coaching can remain inaccessible to people who lack the information, confidence, resources or institutional experience needed to pursue them.

What this means for the GBL model

The frontline evidence suggests that participant progression depends on the capabilities of individual practitioners, as well as the systems that support them. The following priorities emerge from the factors practitioners identified as most critical to effective implementation.

1. Protect the coaching function

Coaching should be recognised as a core component of the model, with defined roles, manageable caseloads, adequate time and appropriate supervision.

2. Invest in the frontline workforce

Recruitment and development should prioritise social development, community development and related competencies, alongside practical coaching, digital and livelihood skills.

3. Ensure dedicated capacity for coaching

Effective coaching requires sufficient time, continuity and attention to individual participant journeys. As the model evolves, implementation should ensure that the coaching function has the capacity and support to do so effectively.

4. Build stronger local opportunity ecosystems

Participant capability needs to be matched by viable opportunities. Partnerships with employers, training providers, enterprise-support organisations, markets and government programmes need to be developed alongside participant support.

5. Design systems around progression

Monitoring should capture the full journey, including changes in confidence, agency, education, skills, financial behaviour and social participation, alongside employment, income and enterprise outcomes.

6. Invest in the coaches' emotional well-being

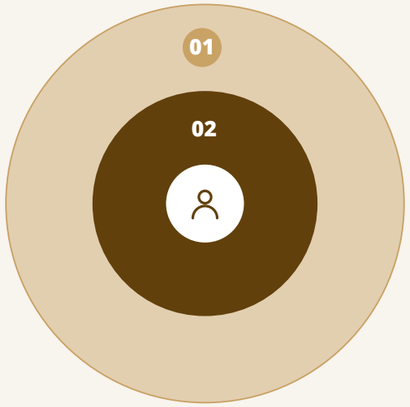
Frontline coaching can involve sustained engagement with participants facing complex social and economic challenges. Regular debriefing, peer support, access to counselling or other wellness services, and appropriate supervision can help practitioners manage these demands and sustain the quality of their support.

What this means for continued investment

The frontline research reinforces a central lesson from the GBL pilot: livelihood progression depends on both relationships and opportunity.

People need support that understands the realities of their lives. They need someone to help them navigate systems and opportunities, build confidence, solve problems and keep going when things become difficult. However, individual support cannot overcome every barrier. People also need access to productive resources, functioning economic ecosystems and real opportunities to earn and grow an income.

This points to the need for continued investment at two levels: strengthening the support around participants, while also improving the systems, resources and opportunities that enable livelihoods to grow.



01 **First, invest in the relationship.**
The coaching function needs to be properly resourced, professionalised and protected. The people doing this work need the skills, time, supervision and institutional support to accompany participants effectively.

02 **Second, invest around the participant.**
Stronger pathways into employment, enterprise, training, finance and productive resources are needed if capability and motivation are to translate into sustained livelihoods.

The two cannot be separated.

The overall lesson

The frontline research shows that livelihood progression is often built through small, persistent interventions: a follow-up call, a home visit, help with an application, a conversation with a training provider, an introduction to an institution, or encouragement when a participant is ready to give up.

These actions may not appear in a participant's CV, but they can determine whether an opportunity is reached, whether a participant remains engaged and whether progress is sustained.

The lesson from GBL is that people can pursue economic opportunities better when support is continuous, relational and connected to the realities of their lives.

The next phase of GBL should build on this learning. Retain the human connection at the centre, strengthen the systems around frontline practitioners, and invest in opportunity ecosystems that turn participant capability into economic progress.



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